remains most valued by most of the leading players. If anyone wants to be respected within the game, they need to perform consistently well in red-ball cricket, meeting both the physical and psychological challenge, demonstrating both courage and technical skill.

There is usually no hiding place over five days of cricket, and there is certainly no hiding place in a series of four or five Tests with only a few days of respite between each match.

It's the ultimate test for a batsman because the leading bowlers in the opposing team will come at you three or four times during the course of a day's play, whereas you only need to face them for either four or 10 overs in the shorter formats. And it's the ultimate test for a bowler because you usually need to earn your wickets through skill and patience, rather than rely on batsmen to give it away in a run chase.

Simply put, Test cricket remains a pure contest, while limited-overs cricket is manufactured.

ODIs represent the middle ground because, for batsmen, they still give you an opportunity to play yourself in and to build an innings; and, for bowlers, there is still time to get into a groove. T20s are a dash for glory for all concerned, an all-action format where either one innings or one spell of bowling often proves decisive.

However, a player's enjoyment of the game is not determined solely by the nature of the contest and, for me at least, it is easier to get the blood pumping for a T20 match played in front of 45 000 chanting spectators than it is to get going on the fifth morning of a Test when there are 450 people in the ground.

Each of the formats has strengths and weaknesses and, in my view, it is crucial for the future of the game that each format is supported, that each format maintains its place in the calendar.

Leading players may well become increasingly specialised, with most playing only two formats because, with the continuing increase in the volume of top-class cricket, including international series and various